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June 14, 2026

Dr. Tara La Rose
MREB Chair
Associate Professor
School of Social Work
Faculty of Social Sciences

Re: Response to ethics review comments from the MREB Chair, MREB#8215

Dear Dr. La Rose:

Thank you and the reviewers for the feedback on our MREB submission. The reviewers provided thoughtful and constructive comments. In response to your e-mail, dated June 8, 2026, we have revised the submission to incorporate the reviewers's feedback. We provide a summary below. Following this, we summarize the non-review related changes to the submission.

Summary of revisions based on the reviews

- 1.3 Is this a post-doc, graduate or undergraduate student project? "If this is primarily Faculty research, then this response is fine as is. However, if the research is primarily for master's student work, then the response should be "yes" in order to add the student as the Student Principal Investigator on the next page and change the response to 2.10 to "no"."

The project supports both faculty and student research, so I have left the response as NO, as instructed in the text of Question 1.3. A student, Ziyang Fang will use the interview data for his MEng report on the state of the practice for motion planning and simulation software. However, the other half of the project, which involves the state of the practice for a different domain (neural network software), is not tied to a student project. The neural network interviews will be done by a PhD student, Christopher Schankula, but not as a part of his PhD research. Chris will assist with writing a paper based on this work, but the ownership of the neural network project is with the faculty member.

- 1.4 Please select the status of your application. "When re-submitting your protocol, be sure to select the first item: 'My revised application in response to ethics review comments from the

MREB Chair’. You will then be prompted to upload your Summary of Revisions document in 1.5 - the subsequent section.”

This has been done. This document provides a summary of the revisions made in response to the ethics review comments.

- 3.3 For which Level of Project(s) will the data be used? (Check all that may apply). “If this is primarily Faculty research then ”Faculty” should also be checked.”

The “Faculty Research” box has now been checked.

- 8.2 Study Purpose/Research Question Description. “Minor comment, this may be a typo, or an incomplete response; ie. is the question mark intentional?”

The question mark was not intentional; it has been removed.

- 10.6.7 Upload your email script(s) sent directly to participants. Please address the following reviewer comments:

- Minor comment, in both emails please add the MREB study number to the statement ‘This study has been reviewed and cleared by the McMaster Research Ethics Board [under study # 8283]’.

The study number has been added to the two emails.

- Be sure to add the student investigators name and email to this draft.

There will be two students involved in the project, Ziyang Fang (Motion Planning and Simulation Software) and Chris Schankula (Neural Network Software). They will add their respective names and email addresses before sending their emails.

- A reviewer suggests adding a note about social risks to this document so that participants can make this consideration early on (refer to comment on 14.6).

The statement about social risks has been added to both recruitment emails.

- Much like you have written in the oral consent script, please include a statement like ‘I located your name/email by visiting the website of research software name.’

This statement has been added to both recruitment emails.

- 10.6.12 Upload your appreciation letter/certificate thank you card for participants. “Minor comment; This reviewer notices a couple of typos ; Appendix title is missing the ‘A’, and ‘...your personal confidentiality would be maintained,’ perhaps intend ‘will be...’ or similar ?”

The typos have been corrected.

- 14.6 Description and management of Social Risks. “Refer to 3rd bullet point on 10.6.7. Some specialized OSS software may have very small development teams, sometimes only 1 developer making anonymity difficult or impossible. You have covered that possibility in this section, however a reviewer believes it would be worth mentioning it in the recruiting email as well.”

A summary of this social risk has been added to both recruitment emails.

- 15.2.2 Describe the administrative purpose(s) for which this information is required. “Please be aware of additional risk related to transfer of emails between password-protected accounts, particularly if the accounts are not within one email system. Also be aware of potential cache or intermediate copies that may be created in email clients (including web browser based clients), or views/previews of attachments on user devices. Any incidental copies should be handled with the same level of security and privacy as the source data.”

The reviewer has a good point about the risks associated with email transfer. Therefore, we will remove the possibility of transferring emails between password-protected accounts. The student investigator who is sending the emails is the only person who needs to know this information. The student investigators will handle the incidental copies (from cache and views/previews on user devices) with the same level of security and privacy as the source data. The change to restrict the data to the student investigators has been propagated to 15.3.1 and 15.3.2. Since there are two student investigators (Chris Schankula and Ziyang Fang) participating in the interviews, both student investigators will have access to the name data. 15.2.2 has been modified to reflect this.

- 15.11.1 Describe how research data will be collected securely. “Please be aware that deleting files or resources on a cloud service may leave a retrievable copy for some length of time (often 30 days). The retrieval should only be possible for users who originally had access. It might be worthwhile to investigate disabling this feature, or simply accommodating or maintaining awareness of the retrieval/undelete time inherent in the cloud platform.”

The reviewer has a good point. Question 15.11.1 has been modified to reflect this. Specifically, the following text was added: “The files will also be deleted from the recycle bin. Deleting on the Microsoft SharePoint platform moves the files to the SharePoint Recycle Bin, also called the Second-stage Recycle Bin. From Microsoft’s documentation, the items will remain in the Second-stage recycle bin for 93 days. After this time, the system automatically deletes them permanently. Only users who originally had access to the files will be able to retrieve them from the recycle bin.”

- 16.6.2 Upload your oral / telephone consent script. Please address the following reviewer comments:
 - This script notes that you are obtaining signed consent “The risks have been described in

the letter of consent that has been signed”. Please clarify in 16.1.

The reviewer’s comment highlights an inconsistency in our original application. Rather than collect signatures, our intention is that consent is granted by replying to the recruitment email with a confirmation. The Oral Consent Script has been modified to remove mention of signed consent. Both of the recruitment emails have been modified to say: “If you choose to participate in the study, please let me know that I have your consent by responding to this email.”

- Please revise to reflect the social risks noted in section 14.

The following line has been added to the Oral Consent Script: “However, maintaining the privacy of interviewed sole developers, or members from a small developer team, may not be possible since their identities can potentially be inferred. The interviewee will have to accept this risk if they choose to be interviewed. ”.

- Please reflect that the data will be stored for 3 years.

The following line has been added to the Oral Consent Script: “The data will be retained for 3 years after the study and then deleted.”

- 16.6.3 Upload your Letter of Information / Consent – Participants.

Please include the following consent bullets before the consent questions:

- I have read the information presented in the information letter about a study being conducted by [Insert researcher’s name(s)], of McMaster University.
- I have had the opportunity to ask questions about my involvement in this study and to receive additional details I requested.
- I understand that if I agree to participate in this study, I may withdraw from the study at any time or up until [insert specific date — e.g., April 15, 2018]
- I have been given a copy of this form.
- I agree to participate in the study.

Since the consent is recorded through an email response, the above items have been added to both of the recruitment emails.

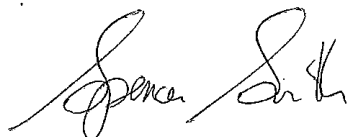
- 16.6.3 Upload your Letter of Information / consent – Participants. Note that our standard consent statement and the ethics office email address have changed. This comment also applies to the consent script in 16.6.2. Please revise the MREB statement to align with the following: ‘This study has been reviewed by the McMaster Research Ethics Board and received ethics clearance under project #8215. If you have concerns or questions about your rights as a participant or about the way the study is conducted, please contact McMaster Research Ethics Office by phone: (905) 525-9140 ext. 23142 or e-mail: mreb@mcmaster.ca.’

The text was updated to reflect the new MREB statement. This change was made in both recruitment emails, the oral consent script and the letter of information.

Summary of non-review related revisions

- An additional Student Investigator, Christopher Schankula has been added. Christopher is a PhD student of Dr. Spencer Smith and Dr. Christopher Anand. This research is not part of Christopher's PhD research, but Christopher will be involved in writing a journal paper. Christopher will complete the interviews for the neural network domain, while Ziyang will conduct the interviews for the motion planning and simulation domain. The addition of Christopher as a student investigator has been propagated through the application.
- The oral consent script has been updated to include wording that there might be a second person involved. Since Christopher has much more experience with interviews than Ziyang, we would like Ziyang to observe some of Christopher's interviews before conducting his own. The following text will be added for the training interviews in the case where Ziyang would like to join Christopher: "If you are agreeable, I would like to ask my colleague Ziyang Fang, another Student Investigator, to join us. Ziyang is new to interview techniques and would benefit from observing. With your consent, I will ask Ziyang to join us. If you prefer, we can proceed without Ziyang." This text will be added to the oral consent script for the first few interviews that Christopher conducts. After Ziyang has observed a few interviews, this text will be removed from the oral consent script.

Best regards,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Spencer Smith', with a stylized, cursive script.

Spencer Smith